

In 1942, Stockhausen left home to attend college in Xanten, but his education was interrupted two years later when he was called up for military service. For the remainder of World War II, he was a stretcher-bearer—an experience that had a deep impact on the unhappy teenager. This was compounded when his father went missing in action, presumed dead, in 1945.

After the war, Stockhausen resumed studies, first at Cologne Conservatory, then at the University of Cologne. In 1952, he moved to Paris to study composition with Olivier Messiaen and Darius Milhaud, before returning to Cologne to work with Herbert Eimert in the electronic music studio of the Nordwestdeutscher Rundfunk.

During the 1950s, Stockhausen developed a distinctive avant-garde approach to composition, which included a methodical, analytical reworking of the serialism invented by Schoenberg, to which he later introduced some elements of indeterminacy. He also explored sound's position in space and electronic music (see box). As his reputation as a composer grew, he became a leading figure of the Darmstadt School, a group of avant-garde and experimental composers.